

Defense Brief

July 15, 2026



Nine Nations Back Ukraine's Freyja Interceptor, US Ammo Production Stalls, NATO Picks Saab Over Boeing for AWACS Replacement

The Bottom Line

July 14-15 marked a significant inflection in European defense sovereignty: nine nations formally backed Ukraine's Freyja interceptor with a 12-month deployment target, NATO chose Saab over Boeing for its next AWACS fleet, and the EU's top envoy argued that European defense spending is now producing real output — not just promises. Meanwhile, the Pentagon's own industrial base problems were on full display: 155-mm shell production stuck at 36% of its target, a \$469 million facility producing zero usable parts, and a CMMC cybersecurity program suspended because it was driving contractors out of the supply chain. The \$87.6 billion Iran war supplemental underscores the scale of the munitions crisis — \$97.3 billion for munitions alone across FY27 — while the Navy's carrier drone RFI and the Golden Fleet's expanding architecture point toward a force structure built for mass and attrition tolerance rather than exquisite platforms.